Celan: Master Grammar Guide

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Celan is the shared language of Ohnosha. Start by learning what the letters sound like. Then learn how the writing works. Once those pieces feel familiar, the sentences are easier to read. Celan words appear like `this`, followed by their English meanings. A capital letter, a space, or a hyphen can change what a word means, so watch for them as you go.

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1. Sound and pronunciation

Say each vowel clearly. Give each syllable room to be heard. Some letter pairs have more than one accepted sound, so two people may pronounce the same written word differently and both be speaking Celan.

1.1 Single vowels

Letter	Guide sound	Example
a	**ah**, as in *father*	Terra — *tehr-rah*
e	**eh**, as in *bed*	Dren — *drehn*
i	**ee**, as in *machine*	Ilin — *ee-leen*
o	**oh**, as in *go*	Morl — *mohrl*
u	**oo**, as in *flu*	Zun — *zoon*

The word I means “I” and sounds like **ee**. It never sounds like the English word *eye*.

1.2 Two vowels together

When two vowels sit together, look at the **pair** before you say the word. Some pairs make two sounds; others can flow together.

Pair	How to say it	Hear it in a word
ae	**ah-eh** (two beats), **ay** as in *day*, or **eye** as in *sky*	Aen: *ah-ehn* or *ayn*; the *eye* reading is also possible.
ai	**eye**	Aiv begins *eyev*.
oa	**oh-ah** or **wah**	Doa: *doh-ah* or *dwah*.
ue	**oo-eh** (two beats)	Arueth: *ah-roo-ehth*.
ua	**oo-ah** (two beats)	Aruaen begins *ah-roo-ah*.

The three sounds of ae are accepted choices. Slow ceremonial speech often lets both vowels sound separately. ai stays **eye**. Keep it apart from the single-letter word I, which is **ee**.

1.3 Consonants and accepted alternatives

Form	Accepted readings	Examples
w	English **w**, or firm **v**	Wek: *wehk* / *vehk*
x	breathy **kh**, or crisp **ks**, at the beginning or inside a word	Xar: *khar* / *ksar*
th	flowing **th** (voiceless as in *think* or voiced as in *this*), or sharply aspirated **t-ha**	Thar: *thahr* / *t-hahr*
sh	as in *shine*	Shal: *shahl*
zh and j	the middle sound of *measure*	Zhir: *zheer*; Joreth: *zhor-eth*
kh	rough sound at the back of the throat	Khumlor
initial mb, nd, nk	a brief nasal hum before the following consonant	Mbalan, Ndem, Nkuvath

Say b, d, g, v, and z with a firm voice. Give k, t, and p a clean stop. Let l and r flow; r may be lightly tapped or rolled. Even in a long word, try to let each syllable be heard.

1.4 The Rule of Euphony

In Celan, this sound-smoothing choice is called the **Rule of Euphony**. Sometimes two word roots join and their consonants bump into each other. A speaker may put a vowel between them so the new word is easier to say. For example, Morl + Thar becomes Morlathar: the extra a gives the mouth a small pause between the roots.

Smoothing does not make a different grammatical meaning. The unsmoothed form can still be valid. a is a common choice; e or o may fit the surrounding sounds better.

Roots coming together	Example	What to notice
Morl + Thar	Morlathar	A smoothing vowel separates a difficult cluster.
Vok + Thal	Vokathar	A smoothed compound can be the familiar form.
Vok + Nor	Voknor, Vokanor, Vokonor	More than one flow is possible.
Krez + Thal	Krezthal, Krezathal	A speaker can keep the cluster or smooth it.

You hear this choice especially in **Verdalrisian** and **Pelagaean** speech. Those national voices often favor a smooth, flowing sound: Krezathal or Belashara. **Zarithan** and **Valkeldorian** speech often keeps the firmer meeting of consonants: Krezthal or Belshara. These are common preferences, not rules that every person from a nation must follow. Other national voices make their own choices of sound and rhythm.

Some roots already flow well together. Kalvok, Kalrath, and Rethlian need no extra vowel. Older words such as Belthal and Rethvok usually keep their familiar form. When Wek **is the second root**, a speaker

may add `e` or `o`, but not `a`: `Belwek`, `Belewek`, and `Belowek` show the choices. This keeps the separate word `Awek` distinct. `Mahrowek` is a chosen spelling with `Mahrwek` as an unsmoothed variant.

When you write an established word, keep its established spelling even if you hear it pronounced with a different flow.

2. Writing and capitalization

In English, we give the first word of every sentence a capital letter. Celan does not do that. An ordinary sentence can begin with a lowercase word:

> `var I an dren.` — “I go to the water.”
>
> `ra var Ya?` — “Where do you go?”

Notice that `var` and `ra` begin those sentences in lowercase. `I` and `Ya` keep their capitals because that is how those pronouns are written. In Celan, a capital tells you something about the **word or its meaning**, not simply where the sentence begins.

2.1 Meaningful capitals

Ask **why** a word has a capital. There are several good reasons, and each one helps the reader.

Why the capital is there	Example	What the reader learns
It is part of the pronoun's spelling.	`I`, `Ya`	These words keep their capitals even in the middle of a sentence: `ohmaen I Ya.` — “I love you.”
It names a particular person or place.	`Kaikoa`	This is a name, not an ordinary description.
It names a nation.	`Mechuma`	The writer means the nation by name.
It marks a particular title.	`Velmarin`	The writer is using a recognized title of respect.
It changes an everyday idea into a great or sacred one.	`terra` → `Terra`	`terra` is ordinary soil or ground; `Terra` is the living, spiritual Heart of the world.
It treats time as a great idea rather than one event.	`rathor` → `Rathor`	`rathor` can mean a past event or memory; `Rathor` is *the Past* as an archetypal force.

A capital can also add **poetic emphasis**. Compare the plain opening `ohmaen I Ya.` with the ceremonial line `Rinaen I an Thar-ka.` — “I am Desire itself.” The capital on `Rinaen` helps the declaration feel elevated; `Thar-ka` names Desire as something larger than an everyday feeling. In poetry, this is a deliberate choice of voice. It does not mean every word about feelings should be capitalized.

When you read a new line, first ask whether a capital belongs to a **name, nation, title, or pronoun**. If none of those fits, ask whether the writer is pointing to a **sacred idea** or adding **poetic weight**. Do not add a capital to an ordinary opening only because English would.

2.2 Hyphens, fused roots, and word boundaries

Celan uses **joined letters**, **hyphens**, and **spaces** for different jobs. Look at these three shapes:

Shape	Example	What the shape tells you
One joined word	`Morl` + `Dren` → `Morldren`	The two roots have become one word: “waterfall.” There is no hyphen between the roots.
A piece attached with a hyphen	`tha-var`	`tha-` belongs to `var`. Together they say “went.” `nor-var` means “will go.”
Two separate words	`ka shal`	`ka` stands on its own and means “without” or “no”: `var I ka shal.` — “I go without light.”

Here is why the marks matter. `I-ka dren` means “my water.” The hyphen joins `-ka` to the owner, `I`. In `var I ka shal.`, `ka` is separate; it means “without.” The two shapes do different jobs.

Some endings attach **after the thing possessed**: `doran-ian` means “my torso,” and `noka-ya` means “your vulva.” A respectful beginning attaches **before a form of address**: `Li-Ser` means “respected friend.” You can see which word each piece belongs to because of the hyphen.

When two roots make a whole new word, write that word as one word: `Morldren`, not a root list with a hyphen added for explanation. The way the parts are written helps the reader tell **word building**, **time**, **possession**, **absence**, and **respect** apart.

3. The basic clause

3.1 Verb–subject–object as the default

In an ordinary Celan sentence, the **action comes first**. Then comes **who does it**. Then comes **the person or thing the action reaches**. Grammar books call this **Verb–Subject–Object**, or **VSO**.

Celan	Follow the parts	English
`var I dren.`	`var` go □ `I` I □ `dren` water	I go to the water.
`var I an dren.`	`var` go □ `I` I □ `an dren` to the water	I go to the water.
`ohmaen I Ya.`	`ohmaen` love □ `I` I □ `Ya` you	I love you.

The first two lines mean the same thing. With `var` (“go”), the place you go can appear as `dren` or as `an dren`. The word `an` makes the link to the place clear. Other movement words may work differently, so learn each word with the sentence pattern used for it.

Putting the action first gives the listener the event before the actor. This is one reason Celan sentences can feel different from English sentences, which often begin with “I” or “you.”

3.2 Who does it, and what comes after?

The **subject** is the one who does the action. It can be a short word such as `I` (“I”), `Ya` (“you”), or `La` (“one other person”). It can also be a noun such as `ser` (“friend”).

The words after the subject answer different questions. They might tell us **whom**, **where**, **with whom**, or **from where**. Read the action and subject first, then ask what the rest adds:

Celan sentence	Action	Who does it?	What the ending adds
`ohmaen I Ya.`	`ohmaen` — love	`I` — I	`Ya` — the person loved: you.
`var I an dren.`	`var` — go	`I` — I	`an dren` — the place I go: to the water.
`var I ser ser.`	`var` — go	`I` — I	`ser ser` — with a friend. The first `ser` means “with”; the second means “friend.”
`tha-var La thal Terra.`	`tha-var` — went	`La` — that person	`thal Terra` — from the Earth.
`moraen I an Varthas.`	`moraen` — stand	`I` — I	`an Varthas` — at the city.

The small words `an`, `ser`, and `thal` show how one part of the sentence relates to another. Their fuller meanings appear in §11. For now, the key is simple: after you find the action and its doer, read the remaining words as the part that completes the thought.

3.3 When one action leads to another

Sometimes a sentence has **two action words**. One tells you what someone **tries, plans, or fails** to do. The other tells you **the action itself**. In “I try to make the hearth,” **try** is the first action word and **make** is the second.

Celan allows **two places for the subject** in this kind of sentence:

Pattern	Celan	Read it step by step
First action □ subject □ second action □ object	`siv I pralaen krezor.`	`siv` try □ `I` I □ `pralaen` make □ `krezor` the hearth. “I try to make the hearth.”
First action □ second action □ subject □ object	`siv gavaen I zor.`	`siv` try □ `gavaen` hunt □ `I` I □ `zor` the animal. “I try to hunt the animal.”

In the first pattern, you learn **who** is trying right after `siv`. In the second, you hear the **two actions together** before you learn who does them. Both are normal ways to build this two-action sentence. The final noun belongs to the **second action**: the hearth is what is made; the animal is what is hunted.

When you meet a long line, count its action words first. If there are two, look for the subject **after the first action** or **after the second**. Then ask what the last part belongs to. This is why the usual VSO pattern is a **starting point**, not a command that every sentence must have exactly one action word.

3.4 Describing and comparing

Once you can name a thing and describe it, you can compare it with another. `ther` means **more than**. Put it after the describing word, then name what you are comparing with. `thaal` means **most** and follows the describing word without a second thing.

What you mean	Shape	Celan and meaning
One thing is **more** than another	thing + description + `ther` + other thing	`rinaen dren-ian shaleth ther La-ka dren.` — “My water is brighter than their water.”
One thing is **the most**	thing + description + `thaal`	`rinaen dren-ian shaleth thaal.` — “My water is brightest.”

In the first sentence, `dren-ian` means “my water,” `La-ka dren` means “their water,” and `ther` opens the comparison between them. The two ways of saying **whose** are explained in §8. In the second sentence, `thaal` makes `shaleth` (“bright”) the strongest degree. `Thaal` can also mean “the Unknown” or “Wonder” as a separate word; its place after a description gives the comparison meaning here.

3.5 Saying “if” with `rath`

`rath` starts a condition: **if this happens**. Say the condition first, then the result. Each part keeps its own action and participants.

Condition	Result	Whole sentence
If the friend goes	I go to the water	`rath var ser, var I dren.`

Condition	Result	Whole sentence
If you go to the water	I will go to the water	`rath var Ya dren, nor-var I dren.`
If you had gone to the water	I would have gotten food	`rath tha-var Ya an dren, tha-talaen I emil.`

The comma helps you see where the **if** part ends. The time pieces on the verbs can change the time or possibility of the thought. `Rath` also has a noun meaning, “enemy”; at the start of these two-part sentences it is the **if** word.

3.6 Saying “who” or “which” with `Lior`

Put `Lior` **after a noun** when the next clause helps identify that noun. Read `Ser Lior var an dren` in pieces: `Ser` is the friend; `Lior` means **who**; `var an dren` says the friend goes to the water. Together: “the friend **who goes to the water**.”

It can be part of a full sentence: `var I an terra ser Ser Lior var an dren.` — “I go home with the friend who goes to the water.” The words after `Lior` describe **which friend**. They do not ask a question.

Look-alike word	Its job	Example
`Lior`	**who/which**: links a noun to a describing clause	`Ser Lior var an dren` — the friend who goes to the water
`Liorin`	**teacher/elder**: names a person	`Liorinen` — honored teacher or elder

The final `in` matters: `Lior` is a linking word; `Liorin` is a person word. They do different jobs even though they look and sound related.

3.7 Joining with `ser` and `reth`

Use `ser` to join things with **and** and `reth` to offer a choice with **or**. For example, `Rinaen morlak ser dren.` joins bread **and** water. `Ra drenaen Ya dren reth phelvin?` asks about water **or** a comforting drink. These short words also have other meanings in different positions: `ser` can mean **with** or **friend**, and `reth` can carry uncertainty. Read the sentence around them to see whether they are joining two things.

4. People, pronouns, and address

4.1 Who is speaking, listening, or being discussed?

Celan has a word for **one**, a special word for **exactly two**, and a word for a **larger group**. First decide who you are talking about. Then choose the right column.

Who is meant?	One person	Exactly two	More than two
The speaker is in the group	`I` — I, me	`Inko` — we two, us two	`Ilin` — we, including the listener; `Imen` — we, excluding the listener
The speaker is talking to them	`Ya` — you	`Yako` — you two	`Yalin` — you all
The speaker is talking about them	`La` — he, she, or they (one person)	`Lako` — those two	`Lalin` — they (a group)

The word `I` sounds like **ee**. `La` does not tell you whether the person is a man, woman, or nonbinary person. The context, or the person's name, can tell you more if you need to know.

Exactly two? Use the middle column. `Var Inko an Varthas.` means “We two are going to the city.” `Ra aen Yako an I?` asks, “Are you two speaking to me?” You do not need a plural word for a pair.

A larger “we”? Ask whether the listener belongs in it. Imagine speaking to a friend about a meal you will share: `Velaen Ilin an morlak.` means “We [you and I] are eating the bread.” Now imagine guards speaking to someone who is leaving them: `Arth Imen an kaleth. Var Ya.` means “We [the guards, not you] protect the fortress. You must go.” The difference between `Ilin` and `Imen` tells the listener whether “we” includes them.

4.2 Naming a person

Pronouns such as `La` can refer to a person without naming their gender. When you do want to name or describe a person, Celan has words that carry more detail:

Word	Meaning	Example of a more specific description
`Kadron`	man or masculine person	`Kadron-Azon` — a man carrying both masculine and feminine qualities
`Azron`	woman or feminine person	`Azron-Theon` — a woman embodying neutrality and balance
`Theon`	neutral or nonbinary person	Can also praise someone whose presence brings balance
`Azon`	feminine man	Names a specific way of describing a person
`Kadon`	masculine woman	Names a specific way of describing a person

These words can describe **identity**, **qualities**, or both, depending on the sentence and the person. Use the word that fits the person you mean. A poetic use of `Theon` does not erase its direct meaning as a neutral or nonbinary person.

4.3 Honorifics and forms of address

In Celan, respect can be **heard and seen in the words**. You may use someone's ordinary name or role, add `Li-` before a form of address, or use an honored title. The choice tells the listener how you are approaching the person.

How you address someone	Celan	What the listener hears
As a friend	`Ser`	friend
With explicit respect	`Li-Ser`	respected friend
As a guardian	`Seren`	guardian
With a higher formal title	`Li-Seren-en`	honored guardian
As an honored elder or teacher	`Liorinen`	honored elder or teacher

Hear the change inside the same sentence: `var I dren, Ser.` means “I go to the water, friend.” `var I dren, Li-Ser.` means “I go to the water, respected friend.” The journey is the same; the speaker's way of addressing the listener changes.

`Li-` goes **before** an address form. `-en` appears **after** certain titles to add honor, as in `Liorinen` and `Li-Seren-en`. Both can appear around a title in a high formal address. These are ways to show respect, not endings to add automatically to every name.

A **title names a role** as well as a level of address. `Ser` means **friend**, while `Seren` means **guardian or protector**; adding letters has not merely made “friend” more polite. `Liorin` means **teacher or elder**, and `Liorinen` honors that person. `Liana` means **Lady**. `Lianor` can be **Sir or respected master** when used as a title; elsewhere the same word can mean **idea or thought**. The person being addressed and the sentence help you hear which meaning is intended.

In a meeting, a speaker might say `Ser` to a friend, `Li-Ser` to mark respect, or an appropriate title when the person's role matters. In a ceremony, an honored title can carry still more weight. This is why honorifics belong near pronouns: first identify **who** is involved, then choose **how to address them**. A specific title or formal address keeps its established capital.

5. Questions, commands, and negation (Ra, Va, Ver)

Three short words can change what a sentence does. Put `ra` at the front to **ask**. Put `va` at the front to **tell someone to act**. Put `ver` just before an action to say it **does not happen**.

5.1 Ask with ra

Start with a simple exchange:

> **Question:** `ra var Ya?` — "Where do you go?"
>
> **Answer:** `var I an dren.` — "I go to the water."

The action still comes before the person: `var Ya` in the question, `var I` in the answer. `ra` tells the listener that the first line asks for an answer. It can also open a yes-or-no question: `ra var ser an dren?` — "Does the friend go to the water?"

When you want to make the missing part **especially clear**, add a short word at the **end** of the question. The ending is optional: `ra var ser?` and `ra var ser lo?` can both ask where the friend goes. The second line spells out that a **place** is wanted.

End word	Ask for…	Celan in action
`mu`	**what** — a thing or matter	`ra tal Ya mu?` — "What do you give?"
`nu`	**when** — a time	`ra var Ya nu?` — "When do you go?"
`zhe`	**why** — a reason	`ra var Ya zhe?` — "Why do you go?"
`sha`	**how** — a way of doing something	`ra pralaen Ya belkor sha?` — "How do you make the tunic?"
`lo`	**where** — a place	`ra var ser lo?` — "Where does the friend go?"
`ri`	**who** — a person	`ra havaen ri?` — "Who laughs?"

Think of `ra` as opening the question. The ending, when you use one, tells the listener **what kind of answer** you want. `ri` works for a person whether English would say *who* or *whom*.

5.2 Give an instruction with va

Put `va` before the action when you want someone to do it:

> `va var an dren!` — "Go to the water!"
>
> `va var Ya an deni.` — "Come here."

The first line leaves the person understood. The second names `Ya` ("you"). Later, you will meet `vael`, which can make a wish or a gentle suggestion. `va` is the direct instruction.

5.3 Say “not” with `ver`

Put `ver` immediately before the action you are saying **does not happen**:

> `var I dren.` — “I go to the water.”
>
> `ver var I dren.` — “I do not go to the water.”

To ask a negative question, keep `ra` at the front and `ver` before the action:

> `ra ver var ser an dren?` — “Does the friend not go to the water?”

`ver` can also come before a noun to say that something does not exist. Do not confuse it with the separate word `ka`, which can mean “without” or “no”: `var I ka shal.` means “I go without light.”

6. Tense, aspect, mood, and voice

The action word can tell you **when** something happens and **what kind of action** it is. Grammarians call these choices **tense** (when), **aspect** (how the action unfolds), **mood** (whether it is wished for or possible), and **voice** (whether we follow the doer or the thing affected). Celan does not change its verb just because the doer changes from “I” to “you.” The chart below keeps `var` (“go”) in every line so you can see what each added piece does.

6.1 When and how an action happens

What you mean	What changes	Celan	English
Going, with no special time marked	Use `var` by itself.	`var I dren.`	I go to the water.
It happened before now.	Add `tha-` before the verb.	`tha-var I dren.`	I went to the water.
It will happen later.	Add `nor-` before the verb.	`nor-var I dren.`	I will go to the water.
It is happening as it continues.	Add `-al` after the verb.	`varal I dren.`	I am going to the water.
See the action as completed.	Add `-ath` after the verb.	`varath I dren.`	I have gone to the water.
It happens regularly.	Add `-as` after the verb.	`varas I dren.`	I usually go to the water.

The time pieces `tha-` and `nor-` come **before** the verb with a hyphen. The endings `-al`, `-ath`, and `-as` come **after** it. These forms stay the same no matter who does the action.

One useful word can look like part of this pattern but has its own meaning. `varal` means “am going”; `varan` means “reside,” “stay,” or “be located.” Compare `varal I dren.` (“I am going to the water”) with `varan I an Varthas.` (“I live or stay in the city”). `-al` marks continuing action; `-an` is not a general continuing-action ending.

6.2 Can, must, might, and want

Sometimes you know **the action**, but you also need to say whether the person **can**, **must**, **might**, or **wants to** do it. Celan puts a short meaning word **after the main action and its subject**. Watch how the last word changes the thought:

Celan	English	What the last word adds
`aen I lianeth.`	“I can speak.”	`lianeth` says I am able.
`var I belshara.`	“I must go.”	`belshara` says I need to.
`var I rethlian.`	“I might go.”	`rethlian` says it is possible.
`var I thar-ka.`	“I want to go.”	`thar-ka` says I desire it.

The first two words give the action and the person: `var I` means “I go.” The last word changes that simple thought to **must go**, **might go**, or **want to go**. English often puts *can*, *must*, or *might* before its verb. Celan's examples place the meaning word after the action and subject.

6.3 The subjunctive: wishes and imagined situations

The **subjunctive** is the way Celan speaks about what someone **wishes for**, **hopes for**, **gently suggests**, or **imagines as if it were real**. Put `vael` at the beginning. Hear how it changes the tone:

Celan	English	What the speaker is doing
`vael vaar an shara-ya.`	“May peace be on your path.”	Offering a blessing.
`vael aen Ya.`	“May you speak” or “Please speak.”	Inviting someone to speak.
`vael rinaen I an eshlin, varal I an esh.`	“If I were a bird, I would be going to the sky.”	Imagining a life that is not real now.

The bird line does not say “I **am** a bird.” It invites us to imagine that I **were** one, then tells us what would follow. This is why `vael` belongs to the subjunctive. A direct order uses `va`; an ordinary “if this happens, then that happens” sentence uses `rath`. `vael` gives room for a wish or imagined possibility.

Verdalrisians often use `vael` in blessings. It lets a speaker offer hope in a gentle, graceful way. Poetic and ceremonial Celan also uses it for that elevated sound. Speakers from other nations can use it too; it belongs to the shared language.

6.4 The passive voice: `nor-ka`

`nor-ka` (/nohr-kah/) is the **passive voice echo particle**. In an active sentence, we watch the **doer**. In a passive sentence, we watch the **person or thing affected by the action**. We may not know the doer, or the doer may simply matter less to the story.

The form brings together **Nor**, the root of time and the flow of events, and **Ka**, which carries absence or a link. Think of an action leaving an **echo in time** even when its doer is absent from the sentence. That picture helps explain why Celan uses `nor-ka` to speak about an outcome or a state left by an action.

Where our attention goes	Celan	English
Active: the doer	`Pralaen an Azron an belkor.`	“The woman makes the tunic.”
Passive: the tunic	`Pralaen an belkor nor-ka.`	“The tunic is made” or “A tunic was made.”

In the first line, `an Azron` names the woman who makes the tunic. In the second, she is left out. `an belkor`, the tunic, becomes the part we care about, and `nor-ka` marks the passive reading. It is a **separate particle**; the verb itself does not need a new ending. The English translation can say **is made** or **was made** as the context requires. The time root **Nor** inside `nor-ka` does not make the particle a future tense marker.

The same pattern lets a speaker tell what happened without naming who did it:

> `Pralaen an kaleth nor-ka.` — “The fortress was built.”
>
> `Talaen an shenakar nor-ka.` — “The coinage was taken.”

The doer **can** still be named while the tunic stays in focus: `pralaen belkor an Azron nor-ka.` means “The tunic was made by the woman.” And words can follow the passive particle: `Shalbalaen felka nor-ka an teremil.` means “The child was born in the home.” Here `an teremil` tells us **where** the birth took place. `nor-ka` therefore marks the passive voice without needing to be the final word of the whole sentence.

In Ohnosha, this way of speaking fits Celan's action-first outlook. It lets a speaker tell what now exists or what happened in time while giving less attention to personal credit. That is part of the expression's cultural force; its grammatical job is to mark the affected person or thing as the focus of a passive sentence.

7. Nouns: which one and how many

A **noun** names a person, place, or thing: a friend, a home, water, or a meal. This section helps you answer three questions about that noun: **Is there one or more than one? Which one do we mean? How many are there?** Section 12 shows how to build larger numbers and do counting with them.

7.1 Regular plural forms

For an ordinary noun ending in a **consonant**, add `-in`. For a noun ending in a **vowel**, add `-n`.

Singular	Plural	Meaning
`ser`	`serin`	friend / friends
`thar`	`tharin`	heart / hearts
`esh`	`eshin`	sky / skies
`dren`	`drenin`	water / waters
`tera`	`teran`	home / homes

Here `-in` means “more than one.” It has another job in some words about **belonging**: `Shalor-in` means “one who belongs to the sanctuary,” not “sanctuaries.” Look at the whole word and its meaning before deciding that an ending marks a plural.

7.2 Which one? Celan and “a” or “the”

English asks us to choose between **a friend** and **the friend**. Celan usually does not place a separate word before a noun just to make that choice. The people speaking, and the situation they share, tell us whether they mean one particular friend or any friend.

For example, `dren` means “water.” In one conversation, it may be simply water; in another, everyone may know which water is being discussed. If you need to point to one particular thing, add words that tell the listener more about it. Do not look for an automatic Celan word matching every English **a** or **the**.

7.3 How many? Broad amounts and exact counts

You can talk about an amount **without counting each thing**. Put the amount word **before the noun**:

Celan amount word	English idea	What it tells you
`ilinor`	all	None are left out.
`melen`	many	There is a large group.
`som`	some, a few	There are some, without an exact count.
`felin`	few	The group is small.
`ekor`	each, every	We look at the members one by one.

For example, `var som serin.` means “Some friends go,” while `var felin serin.` means “Few friends go.” The amount word comes before `serin` (“friends”) in both lines.

When you need an **exact count**, use a number. These are the first five:

1	2	3	4	5
`unar`	`del`	`tren`	`quen`	`peth`

The number comes before the measured thing in `peth shen` — “five measures.” So Section 7 gives you the noun and its amount; §12 teaches the rest of the number system, including ten, hundreds, thousands, and subtraction.

8. Possession and relationship

Celan has more than one way to say **whose something is**. You can name the possessor **before** the thing, or put a personal ending **after** the thing. Celan can also name **the bond** between people or between people and things. First look at where the connecting form goes:

What are you saying?	Where does the form go?	Example and meaning
Whose is it?	Name a possessor **before** the thing	`I-ka dren` — my water; `anen morlak` — your bread
Whose is it?	Put a personal ending **after** the thing	`doran-ian` — my torso; `dren-ian` — my water
What bond does it express?	Put a bond ending on the word	`Kalvokesh` — the spouse's family; `Morlak-vel` — bread shared among us

The first two rows both answer **whose?** They use different forms. The third row answers **what kind of connection?** That distinction will help you read the sections below.

8.1 Whose thing is it?

To name a possessor, put `-ka` after the person, group, place, or title, then name the thing. The hyphen shows that `-ka` belongs to the possessor:

Possessor	Celan	English
I	`I-ka dren`	my water
You	`Ya-ka tera`	your home
We	`Ilin-ka emil`	our meal
Another person	`La-ka kelvor`	their mouth
A place or title	`Varthas-ka vorkor`; `Seren-ka arthkal`	the city's gate; the guardian's shield

In a sentence: `rinaen I-ka dren an drenvor.` — “My water is in the bowl.” The water is in the bowl; `I-ka` tells us whose water it is.

Celan also has **possessive words that stand on their own before the noun**. `anen` means **your**, and `velian` means **our**. The space matters: each word sits before the thing it describes.

Phrase	Full sentence	Meaning
`anen morlak`	`rinaen anen morlak an pralor.`	“Your bread is on the table.”
`velian morlak`	`rinaen velian morlak an pralor.`	“Our bread is on the table.”

`Ya-ka tera` (“your home”) and `anen morlak` (“your bread”) both answer **whose?** In the first pattern, `-ka` attaches to `Ya` (“you”). In the second, `anen` stands before the thing. Both express **your**. Neither form adds a special level of formality.

Likewise, `Ilin-ka emil` (“our meal”) and `velian morlak` (“our bread”) answer **whose?** `Morlak-vel` means something more specific: bread **shared among us**. That shared bond is explained in §8.3.

8.2 Putting a personal ending after the thing

These endings say **my**, **your**, or **his/her/their** by attaching directly to the thing. They are especially useful for body parts, inner states, personal clothing, and primary personal gear. With `doran-ian`, the ending `-ian` is attached to `doran` (“torso”):

Ending	Whose?	Example in use
`-ian`	mine	`doran-ian` — “my torso”; `rinaen aiv an doran-ian.` — “There is pain in my torso.”
`-ya`	yours	`noka-ya` — “your vulva.”
`-oshen`	his, hers, or theirs (one person)	`rinaen kelvor-oshen kadreneth.` — “Their mouth is dry.”

Personal describes **whose** it is, not a strict list of things the ending can follow. `dren-ian` means “my water” in the comparison you saw in §3.4; water is neither a body part nor a piece of clothing. `I-ka dren` also means “my water.” Both forms answer **whose water?** Their spelling shows which pattern the speaker used.

`-ian` means **my**; `-oshen` means **his, hers, or theirs** for one person. Compare `kelvor-oshen` and `La-ka kelvor`: both can tell us “their mouth.” One puts an ending on **mouth**; the other puts `-ka` on the person. Read the whole phrase to see which pattern is being used.

8.3 What kind of bond is it?

Possession is not the only way to link people and things. Celan can name the **kind of relationship**. These endings say more than a plain “belongs to.” The spellings `-oshen` and `-esh` are distinct, and they answer different questions:

Ending	Question it answers	Example
`-oshen`	**Whose is it?** — his, hers, or theirs (one person)	`kelvor-oshen` — “their mouth”
`-esh`	**What bond is there?** — a deep personal or family tie	`Kalvokesh` — “the spouse's family”

Read the **whole ending**. `-oshen` identifies whose thing it is; `-esh` names a deep personal or family bond. The first begins with `o` and the second with `e`. Here are the bond endings together:

Ending	Bond it points to	Example	What the example means
`-esh`	A deep personal or family bond	`Kalvok` — spouse → `Kalvokesh`	The spouse's family: people joined through the spouse.
`-el`	Affection, endearment, or a beloved bond	`Ohmbaen-el`	A beloved named with affection.
`-vel`	A communal or shared bond	`Morlak-vel`	Bread shared among us.

Compare `velian morlak` (“our bread”) and `Morlak-vel` (“bread shared among us”). The first answers **whose bread?** The second answers **what bond does this bread express?** In the same way, `Kalvokesh` names a family tie; `-esh` does not simply mean “his,” “her,” or “their.” Keep each form's spelling: `Kalvokesh` is joined, while `Ohmbaen-el` and `Morlak-vel` show a hyphen.

9. Ka: the relational pin

Why give such a small word its own chapter? Ka appears in several important parts of Celan, but these are not five unrelated words that happen to look alike. Its central job is to **pin, link, or mark a boundary**. In grammar, this makes ka a **deictic anchor**: a word piece that helps point out how one part of an expression relates to another. You can think of it as a **relational pin**.

What ka pins depends on the words around it. Sometimes it links a person to a thing. Sometimes it marks what is absent. In a larger expression, it can help frame an event, a moment, or a desire. **Spaces, hyphens, and the whole expression** show which relationship is meant.

What you see	What ka pins or marks	Example in use
ka as a separate word	A boundary of **absence**: **without** or **no**	var I ka shal. — "I go without light." Ka. — "No."
-ka after a possessor	A **link** between that possessor and a thing	I-ka dren — "my water"; Ya-ka tera — "your home."
nor-ka after the affected thing	An event with the doer **left out or in the background**: the **passive voice echo**	Pralaen an belkor nor-ka. — "The tunic is made / A tunic was made."
an nor-ka as a time phrase	The event's place in time: **this moment**, **at present**	Shal lorin shara-ya an nor-ka, Ser? — "Does the light guide your path in this moment, friend?"
Thar-ka	A link between an action and **desire**: **want to**	var I thar-ka. — "I want to go."

Compare I-ka dren ("my water") with var I ka shal. ("I go without light"). The first -ka is attached to I and answers **whose water?** The second ka stands alone and means **without**. Moving the space or hyphen changes what the reader sees.

In Pralaen an belkor nor-ka., the tunic receives the action while its maker stays out of view; see §6.4. In an nor-ka, the phrase points to the present moment. In var I thar-ka., thar-ka ties going to wanting; see §6.2. The same relational idea runs through these uses, while each **whole expression** tells you its particular meaning.

10. Roots, derivation, and compounds

10.1 Roots and established words

Celan often builds a word around a **root**: a short piece that carries a central idea. `Dren` carries **water or flow**. `Krez` carries **fire or heat**. A root can stand as a word, take a word-building piece, or meet another root. The new word grows from the root's idea, but it has its **own meaning**.

Follow one root through the system:

Step	Celan	What changed?
Root	`Dren` — water	The core idea is water.
Root with an action ending	`drenaen` — to drink	`-aen` turns the water idea into an action.
Two roots together	`Dren` + `Shal` → `Drenshal` — reflective pool or clear spring	Water and light meet in one established word.

This gives you a way to **read** an unfamiliar word. First, find any root you know. Next, look for another root or an ending. Then ask what the **whole word** means in the sentence. `Dren` + `Shal` helps you picture water and light, but `Drenshal` names a particular kind of place. It does not mean every instance of water touched by light.

The same root can also help you remember a **family of related words**. That family is a memory aid, not a rule that lets you invent a meaning for every possible combination. The established spelling and the sentence tell you which word you actually have. Sections 10.2 and 10.3 show the two main ways words grow: **joining roots** and **adding pieces**.

10.2 Compounding

Two or more roots can join to make **one new word**. The first root gives a starting idea. The next root adds something to it. Look at what each part means, then look at what speakers mean by the **whole word**:

First part	Next part	Whole word	Meaning of the whole word
`Morl` — mountain	`Dren` — water	`Morldren`	Waterfall.
`Terra` — earth, ground	`Dren` — water	`Terradren`	Fertile soil or well-irrigated land.
`Dren` — water	`Shal` — light, new beginnings	`Drenshal`	Reflective pool or crystal-clear spring.
`Terra` — earth, ground	`Esh` — sky, air	`Terraesh`	Horizon: where earth meets sky.
`Bel` — bind, weave	`Pral` — make, craft; `Mek` — construction, making	`Belpralmek`	Loom: a machine used to weave cloth.

The parts are **clues**, not a complete translation. **Mountain + water** helps you picture `Morldren`, but the word means a **waterfall**, not any water on a mountain. **Earth + water** might make you imagine mud. `Terradren` has a more particular meaning: **fertile or well-watered soil**. **Water + light** does not name

every sunlit drop; `Drenshal` names a **reflective pool or clear spring**. People give these whole words their familiar meanings through use.

This is where the **Rule of Euphony** comes back into word building. When two roots meet and their consonants are hard to say together, a speaker may add a vowel to make the whole word flow. `Morl` + `Thar` gives `Morlathar`; the extra `a` helps the roots meet. `Krezthal` and `Krezathal` show another choice: keep the consonants together, or smooth them with `a`. The smoothing vowel helps **pronunciation**; it is not a third root and does not add a new meaning. Verdalrisian and Pelagaean voices often favor the smoother sound, while Zarithan and Valkeldorian voices often keep the firmer cluster. The Rule of Euphony allows this choice; it does not force every speaker to smooth every word.

When you write an established compound, keep its whole-word spelling. `Morldren` is written as one word. Splitting it into `Morl` + `Dren` is useful while learning, but that is a way to **explain** the word, not the way to write it in a sentence.

10.3 Common word-building pieces

Small pieces can change what a root does. The forms below have clear jobs, but each finished word has its own meaning and spelling.

Piece	What it can do	Root and meaning	Finished word and meaning
`-aen`	Make an action word.	`Dren` — water	`drenaen` — to drink.
`-or`	Name a place.	`Shal` — light	`Shalor` — sanctuary, a light-filled place.
`-en`	Add honor or respect.	`Liorin` — elder or teacher	`Liorinen` — honored elder or teacher.
`-lin`	Carry a collective or smallness sense in some words.	`I` — I	`Ilin` — we, including the listener.
`-eth`	Give a root's quality.	`Kal` — strength; `Wor` — abundance	`Kaleth` — strong; `Woreth` — full or abundant.
`-eth`	Help name a ceremonial or sacred act.	`Khum` — circle, listening, reconciliation	`Khumeth` — a sacred ritual or ceremony.

The two `-eth` rows show why you must read the **whole word**. The ending can help describe a quality, but it also appears in ritual nouns. `Kaleth` itself can mean **strong** as an adjective and **fortress** as a noun. The surrounding sentence tells you which meaning fits.

10.4 What does a small piece change?

Small pieces do not all work at the same level. Some **make a new word**. Others tell you **when an action happens**, **whether it happens**, or **how someone is addressed**. Compare what each piece changes:

Piece	Where it goes	What it changes
`-aen`	After a root: `Dren` → `drenaen`	Makes a **new action word**: water → drink.

Piece	Where it goes	What it changes
`Li-`	Before an address form: `Ser` → `Li-Ser`	Adds **respect** to the way someone is addressed; see §4.3.
`tha-`	Before a verb: `var` → `tha-var`	Places the **same action in the past**: go → went.
`nor-`	Before a verb: `var` → `nor-var`	Places the **same action in the future**: go → will go.
`ver`	As a separate word before a verb: `ver var`	Says the action **does not happen**: do not go.

Here is the test: **Does the piece make a new word, change an action, or change an address?** `Drenaen` is a new verb built from `Dren`. `Tha-var`, `nor-var`, and `ver var` still concern **going**; they change its time or whether it happens. `Li-Ser` still addresses a friend, but with respect. That is why the pieces have different places in Celan grammar.

11. Relations of place, time, and accompaniment

These short words tell you **where**, **when**, **with whom**, or **without what** something happens. Read them beside the words they connect. Some also have a noun or verb meaning elsewhere; the sentence shows which job they are doing here.

What you want to show	Celan form	Sentence	Meaning
Going **with** someone	`ser`	`Var I ser Yalin.`	I go **with** you all.
Coming **from** somewhere	`thal`	`Tha-var La thal Shalor.`	They went **from** the sanctuary of light.
Being **without** something	`ka`	`var I ka shal.`	I go **without** light.
Being **above** something	`esh`	`var I esh dren.`	I go **above** the water.
Being **beneath** something	`morl`	`var I morl dren.`	I go **under** the water.
Being **in** a place	`an`	`Varan I an Varthas.`	I reside **in** the city.
Acting **during** a time	`nor`	`dovaen I nor kilveth.`	I play **in** the evening.

`An` often marks a place, but it also appears in established time expressions: `an kinnmor` means “in the morning.” `Nor` makes time explicit in `nor Kinnmor`. The two words are not an absolute place-versus-time pair.

Movement has its own pattern with `var` (“go”). `var I dren.` can mean “I go to the water,” with the goal following the verb; `var I an dren.` gives an explicit relation. See §3.1. This pattern belongs to `var`; it does not tell you to leave relation words out after every motion verb.

12. Counting and measure

Celan builds large numbers from **small number words plus scale markers**. You learn the base numbers once, then put a marker in front to say **tens**, **hundreds**, **thousands**, or more. A long number is read from the largest part down to the smallest part.

Measuring has an Ohnoshan feel as well. Units are tied to things people can picture: **the width of a hand**, **a stride**, **a day's journey**, **a breath**, or **a cycle of the moon**. These familiar benchmarks make length, time, and quantity easier to imagine. First learn how the numbers are built; then see how they work with those units.

12.1 Base numbers

Number	Celan	Number	Celan
0	`verin`	6	`senar`
1	`unar`	7	`sethe`
2	`del`	8	`oven`
3	`tren`	9	`nevar`
4	`quen`	10	`tenar`
5	`peth`		

12.2 Scale markers and additive order

Large numbers are built with scale markers. State the **larger unit before the smaller**; adjacent number blocks are added in interpretation.

Scale	Marker	Example	Read the calculation
Tens	`Ten-`	`Ten-del`	2 × 10 = **20**
Hundreds	`Hek-`	`Hek-quen`	4 × 100 = **400**
Thousands	`Mel-`	`Mel-unar`	1 × 1,000 = **1,000**
Tens of thousands	`Fen-`	`Fen-peth`	5 × 10,000 = **50,000**
Hundreds of thousands	`Hek-Mel-`	`Hek-Mel-unar`	1 × 100,000 = **100,000**

The **hyphen** joins a scale marker to its number. A **space** begins the next block. For example, `Ten-del peth` places the twenty block before five. Together they make twenty-five. The full equations are in §12.3.

12.3 Reading the equations

Putting number blocks next to each other **adds** them. `Ven` between two number expressions means **minus**. Here is the arithmetic written out, so you can check every part:

Celan	Equation	Result
`tenar unar`	10 + 1	**11**
`Ten-del peth`	(2 × 10) + 5 = 20 + 5	**25**
`Hek-quen Ten-peth`	(4 × 100) + (5 × 10) = 400 + 50	**450**
`Hek-oven Ten-quen del`	(8 × 100) + (4 × 10) + 2 = 800 + 40 + 2	**842**
`Mel-quen Hek-sethe Ten-oven sethe`	(4 × 1,000) + (7 × 100) + (8 × 10) + 7 = 4,000 + 700 + 80 + 7	**4,787**
`Hek-quen Ven Hek-del`	400 − 200	**200**
`Mel-quen Ven Hek-peth`	4,000 − 500	**3,500**

The **×** sign in this chart explains what a **scale prefix** means; it is not a separate Celan multiplication word. The **+** signs show what happens when you place number blocks in order. `Ven` is the Celan word that explicitly marks subtraction.

12.4 Measuring the world

After the number, name the unit. Each unit gives the number a real-world size:

Unit	What it measures	Example
`korineth` — handspan	Small lengths, such as craftwork	`Ten-del korineth` — 20 handspans
`shar` — stride	Rooms, fields, and medium distances	`Hek-unar shar` — 100 strides
`kinnshara` — day's journey	Long walking distance	`Ten-peth kinnshara` — 50 days' journeys
`aenor` — breath-long moment	A short span of time	`an aenor` — in a moment
`lunwek` — moon cycle	A month	`unar lunwek` — one month
`shen` — measure	A small trade quantity	`peth shen` — five measures

`Shen` can also refer to coinage. In `peth shen`, the surrounding sentence tells you whether someone means five measures or five units of currency. The pattern **number before unit** stays the same.

13. One language, eight cultural voices

Celan is shared across Ohnosha. Its nations use the same grammar, but people may choose different images, levels of formality, and rhythms. To hear the difference, imagine two friends meeting in a neutral market. One asks where the other is going; the other is looking for a drink. The **situation stays the same** while each pair of speakers shapes it in a national voice.

Zarithan — direct and practical

> **A:** `Ra min Ya, Ser?` — “Where are you headed, friend?”
>
> **B:** `Min I an dren. Rinaen kelvor-ian kadreneth ser Krez.` — “Headed to water. My mouth is dry with the heat.”

The question goes straight to the destination. The answer names water and heat as immediate needs.

Verdalrisian — patient and lyrical

> **A:** `Lorin shara Ya an Kinnmor, Li-Ser?` — “Where does your path guide you this morning, respected friend?”
>
> **B:** `Theraen thar-ian an awek. Rinaen an-rin lian morlak kadreneth.` — “My heart longs for the spring. It feels like the truth of dry bread.”

The journey becomes a **guided path**; thirst is spoken through longing and image. `Li-Ser` adds respect to the greeting.

Mechuman — precise and purposeful

> **A:** `Aen Ya varash, Ser.` — “State your destination, friend.”
>
> **B:** `Var I an phelvin. Rinaen kelvor-ian kadreneth. Rinaen belshara.` — “Proceeding to acquire a beverage. My mouth is dry. Hydration is a necessity.”

The request asks for a destination, and the reply gives a goal, a condition, and a reason.

Pelagaean — flowing and communal

> **A:** `Ra shalil Ya, Ser?` — “Where do you flow, friend?”
>
> **B:** `Shalil I an dren. Rinaen thar-ian ser mahr kadreneth.` — “I flow to the water. My heart feels like a dry sea.”

Movement becomes **flow**. Even thirst is pictured through water and sea.

Valkeldorian — firm and resolute

> **A:** `Aen shara-ya, Ser!` — “State your path, friend!”
>
> **B:** `Var I an velithor. Rinaen thar-ian moreth, ser vaar ka.` — “I'm going for strong ale. My spirit is hard and unsettled, and lacks comfort.”

The exchange is forceful. Path, strength, and discomfort are spoken plainly.

Nivveilian — quiet and restrained

> **A:** `An eshreth, ra var Ya, Ser?` — “In this hazy sky, where are you going, friend?”
>
> **B:** `Var I an phelvin. Arth vel vaar.` — “I am going for a warm drink. Calm endurance preserves peace.”

The speaker notices the sky, then answers briefly. Endurance carries more weight than an elaborate account of thirst.

Jasaran — practical need and sacred balance

> **A:** `Shal lorin shara-ya an nor-ka, Ser?` — “Does the light guide your path in this moment, friend?”
>
> **B:** `Lia, var I an Drenkorath. Rinaen vethor an thar-ian.` — “Yes, I go to the sacred spring. There is a shadow in my heart.”

The speaker has a destination, but light, the present moment, and an inner shadow shape how it is said.

Marakorian — formal and orderly

> **A:** `Ra rinaen shara-ya lian, Li-Ser?` — “Is your path a proper one, respected friend?”
>
> **B:** `Lia. Var I an phelvin. Lorin belthal kel-ian.` — “Yes. I am going for a comforting drink. My actions are guided by order.”

The exchange gives the journey a question of propriety. `Li-Ser` and the closing thought about order keep the tone formal.

These are **national tendencies**, not rules that every person must follow. A speaker can be brief, poetic, formal, or direct because of the person they are addressing and the moment they are in. The shared grammar makes every exchange recognizable as Celan; the choices make each voice lived in.

14. Construction checklist

The following sequence is a compact way to analyze or compose a Celan form without losing its distinctions:

1. **Name the action or state.** Begin a standard clause with its verb. Keep VSO as the primary frame, while recognizing the specific permitted multi-verb orders.
2. **Name the participants.** Select the appropriate pronoun or noun, including dual and inclusive/exclusive distinctions where they matter.
3. **Add the object or relation.** Use the verb's attested frame. Mark place, time, accompaniment, origin, or absence explicitly when needed.
4. **Set the sentence type.** Put `ra` before a question, `va` before a direct command, and `ver` immediately before the verb for negation. Add an optional content-question tail when it clarifies what answer is sought.
5. **Set time and aspect.** Attach `tha-` or `nor-` for past or future. Use the attested aspect suffix for continuous, perfective, or habitual meaning. Keep `Varan` separate from continuous `-al`.
6. **Build the noun phrase.** Apply the appropriate plural, quantifier, number, possession, or relational form. Keep `-ka` attached to a possessor and standalone `ka` separate.
7. **Link clauses deliberately.** Use `rath` for a condition, `Lior` for a relative clause, and `ser` or `reth` for conjunction when the intended relation calls for them.
8. **Check the written form.** Preserve established headword spellings, meaningful capitals, and grammatical hyphens. Do not capitalize an ordinary opening just because it begins a sentence.
9. **Read for social context.** A respectful title, a national metaphor, or a smoothed pronunciation can change tone without changing the shared grammar.

This guide is a single current grammar narrative. It can be divided into database sections without changing the rule text or teaching examples: sound; writing; clause structure; person; questions and commands; verb system; nouns; possession; word formation; relations; number; linked clauses; and social use.